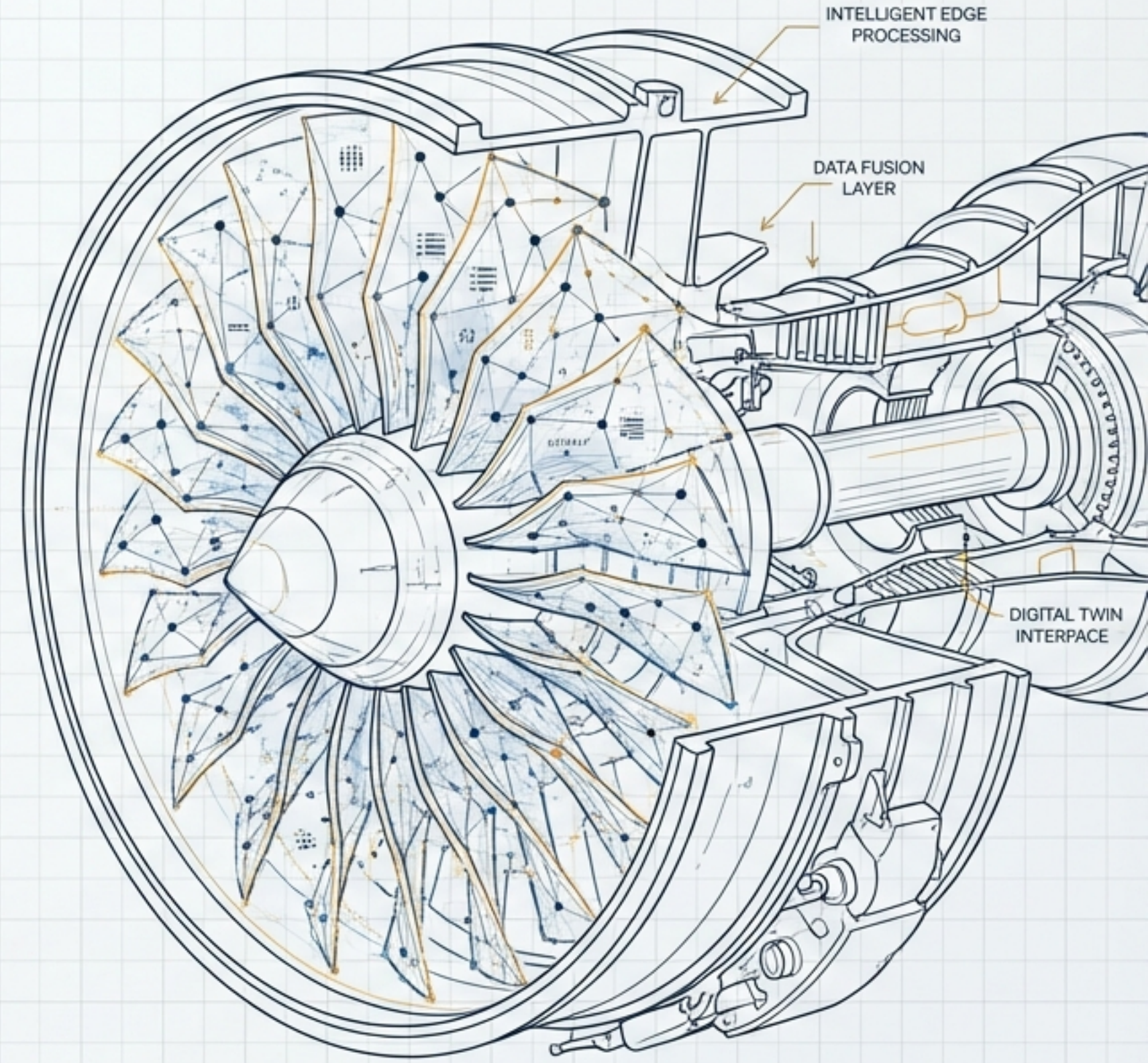


Enterprise AI & Automation for Aerospace: A Strategic Comparative Analysis

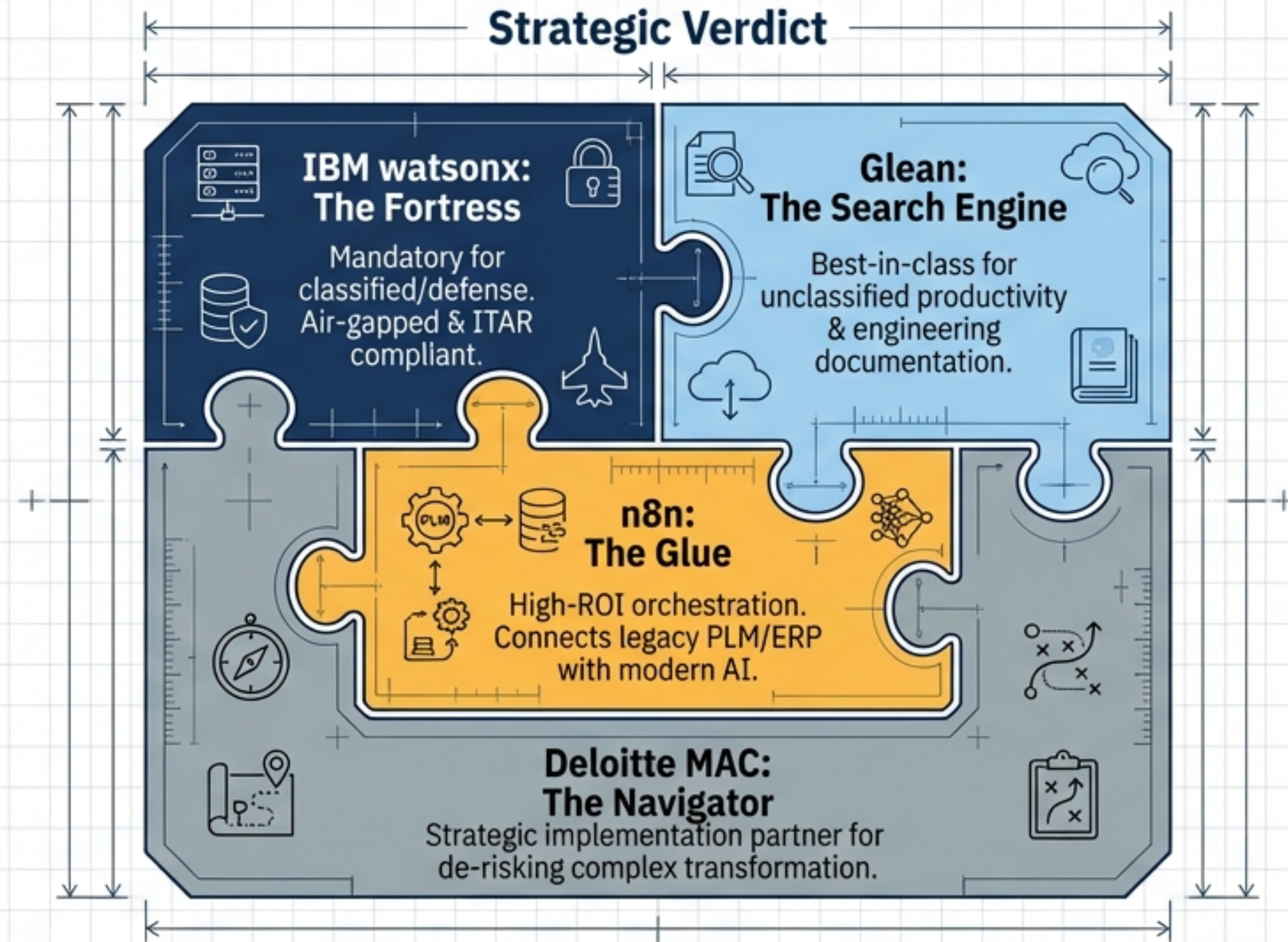
Evaluating n8n, IBM watsonx, Glean,
and Deloitte MAC Against Mission-Critical
Requirements

Internal Evaluation Report | 2026 Strategic Outlook

Target Entities: n8n (Workflow Orchestration), IBM watsonx
(Enterprise AI Platform), Glean (Knowledge Discovery),
Deloitte MAC (Managed Services)



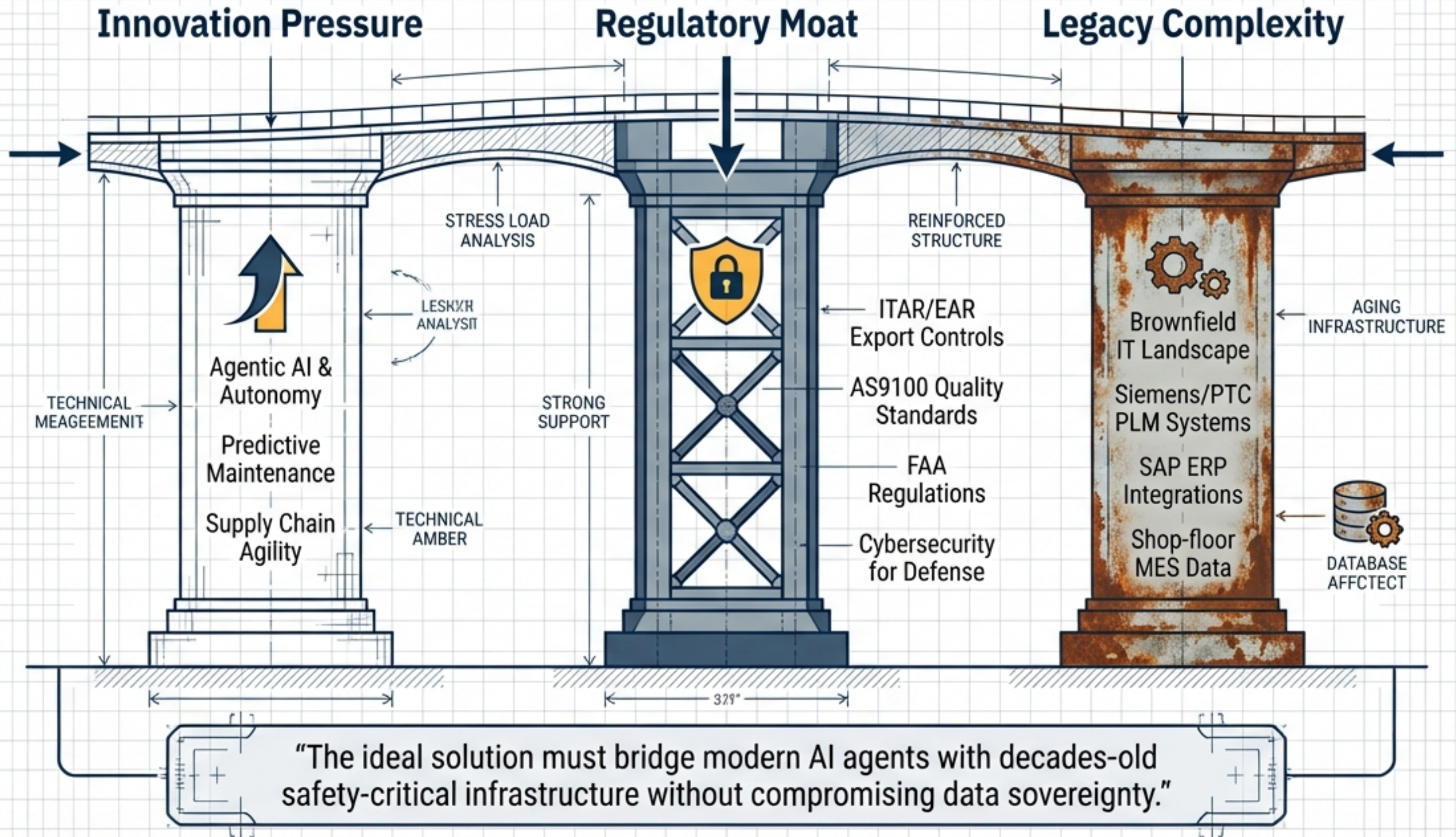
The Aerospace AI Stack Requires a Unified Ecosystem, Not a Single Vendor



Key Insight:

These platforms occupy distinct layers of the enterprise stack. Success lies in architectural integration, not winner-takes-all selection.

Balancing Innovation Pressure with Regulatory Moats



Defining the Contenders: Four Distinct Approaches to Enterprise Value



n8n

Workflow Orchestration

Open-source,
code-flexible automation.
The "Pipes" connecting
API endpoints.
1,700+ pre-built
integrations.



IBM watsonx

Enterprise AI Platform

Comprehensive model
lifecycle & governance.
The "Brain" for secure AI.
Air-gapped capable; IBM
Defense Model.



Glean

Knowledge Discovery

AI-powered enterprise
search.
The "Index" for
unclassified data.
Knowledge Graph across
100+ apps.

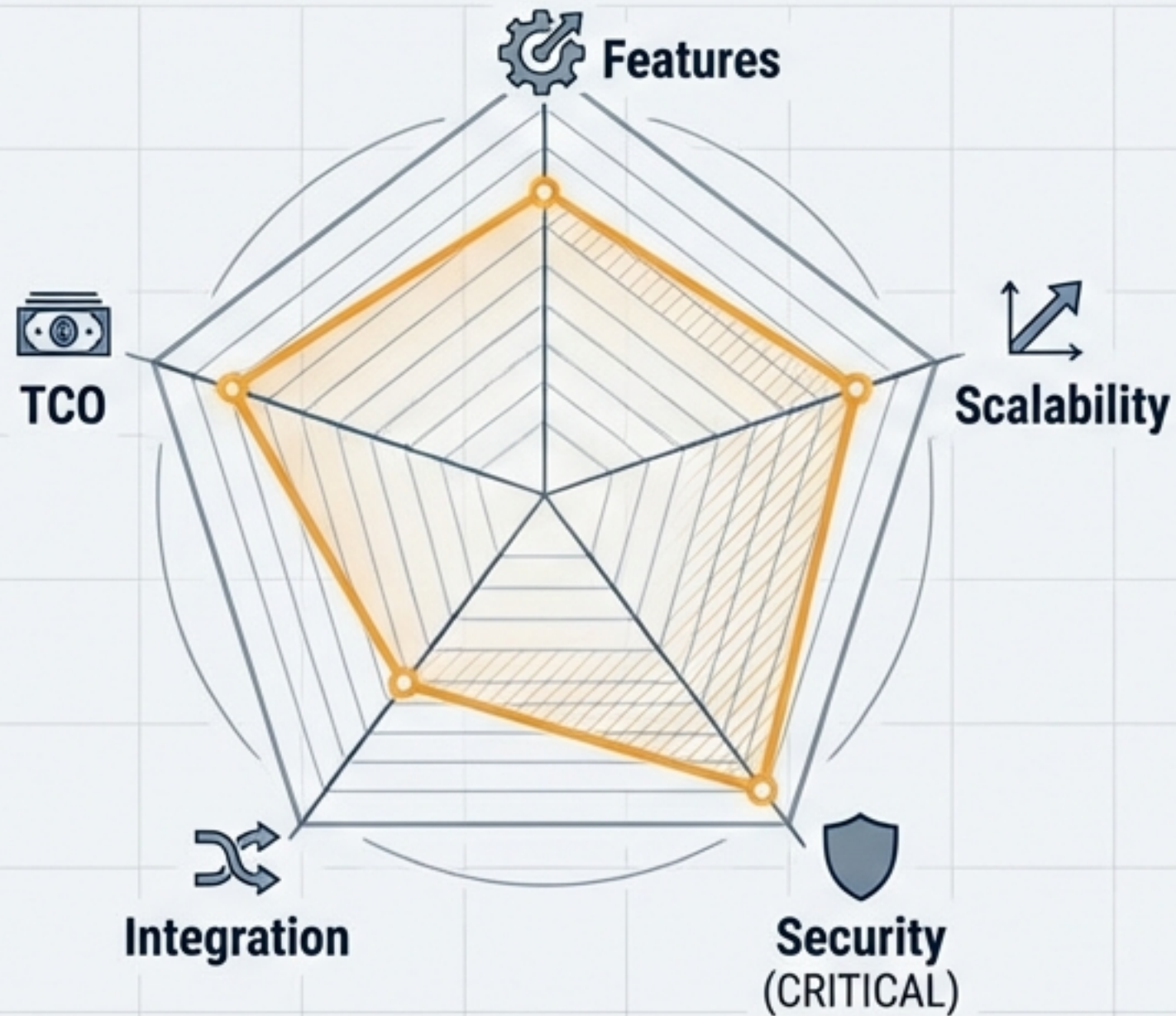


Deloitte MAC

Services & Strategy

Managed Analytics &
Cognitive Services.
The "Strategy" for
implementation.
Human-centered design
& risk mitigation.

Evaluation Methodology tailored for High-Stakes Environments



1. Features

Aerospace Specific: AI integration, automation depth.



2. Scalability

Handling telemetry logs & large datasets.



3. Security (CRITICAL)

The primary filter. ITAR, SOC 2, Air-gapped requirements.



4. Integration

Compatibility with PLM (Teamcenter/Windchill) and MES.



5. TCO

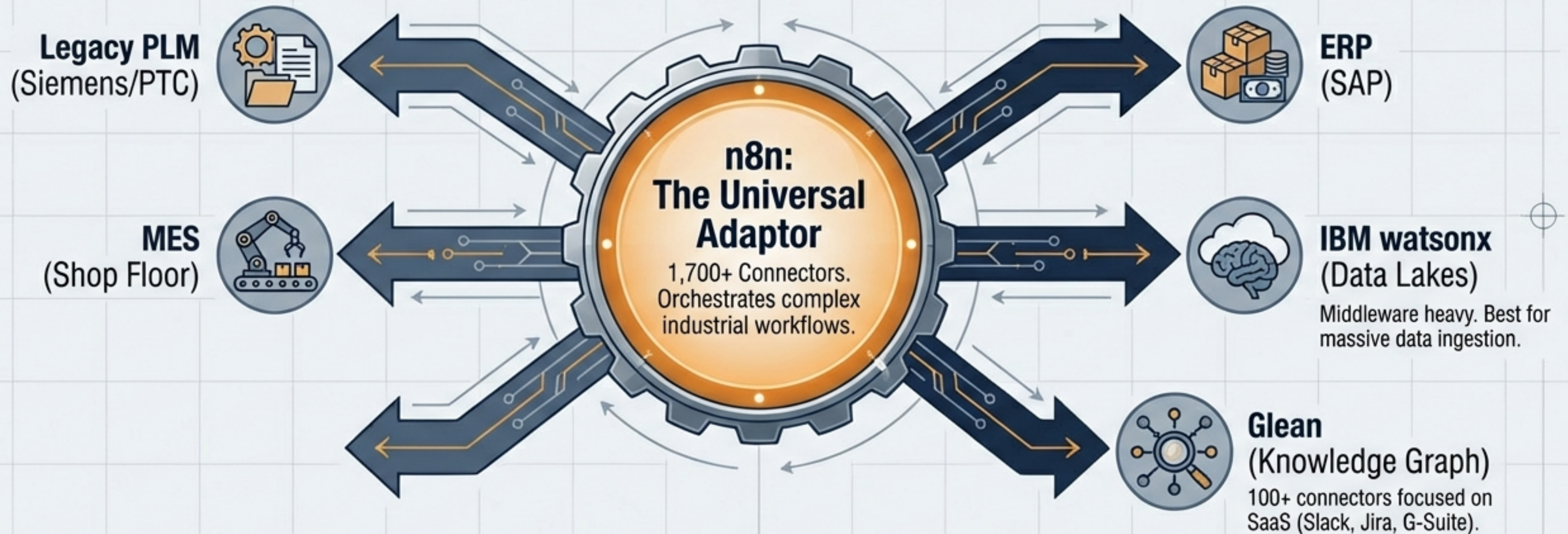
Licensing vs. Infrastructure vs. Services.

Criteria are weighted heavily toward **Security** (can it run **air-gapped**?) and **Integration** (can it talk to legacy manufacturing systems?).

Security & Compliance: The Aerospace 'Red Line'

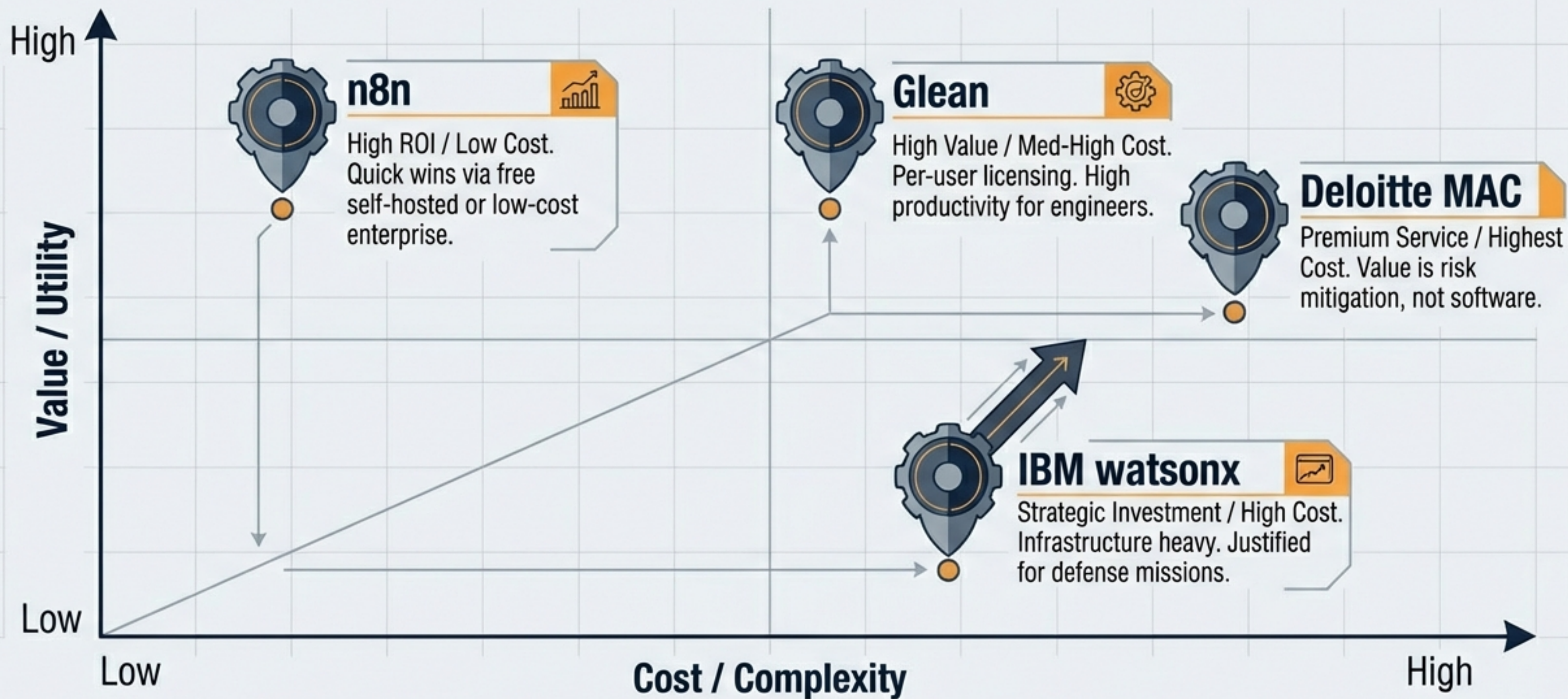
Vendor	Verdict	Capability	Details
IBM watsonX	LEAD	Air-gapped / Defense Ready	Includes "IBM Defense Model" trained on military doctrine. ISO/IEC 42001 certified. ITAR ready.
n8n	STRONG	Self-Hosted / Data Sovereignty	Self-hosted architecture enables full control. ITAR compliant when deployed on-prem. SOC 2/3 certified.
Glean	LIMITED	SaaS Only / Commercial	Enterprise-grade SOC 2, but data resides in cloud (AWS). Restricted use for classified/ITAR data.
Deloitte.	ENABLER	Governance Framework	Designs the framework to map regulatory obligations (FAA/EU AI Act) to controls.

Integration Capabilities: Connecting the 'Messy' Reality of Aerospace IT



n8n provides the necessary 'glue' to make the static data in PLM systems accessible to the AI models in watsonx and the search index in Glean.

Total Cost of Ownership (TCO) & Value Realization

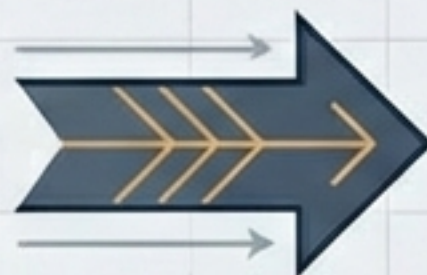


Use Case: Accelerating Engineering & Design Cycles



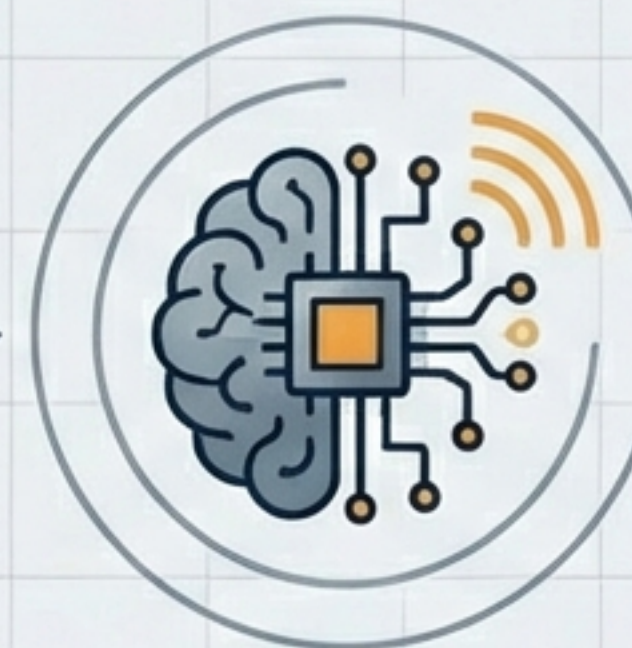
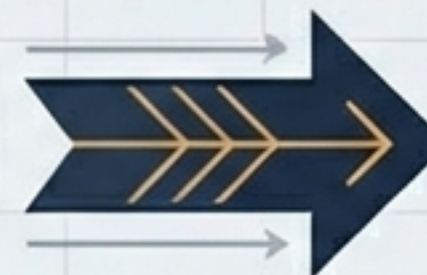
Discovery (Glean)

Engineer searches 'landing gear vibration tests 2020-2024' across SharePoint/Confluence.



Retrieval (n8n)

Workflow triggers retrieval of CAD files and raw telemetry from secure PLM (Teamcenter).



Optimization (watsonx)

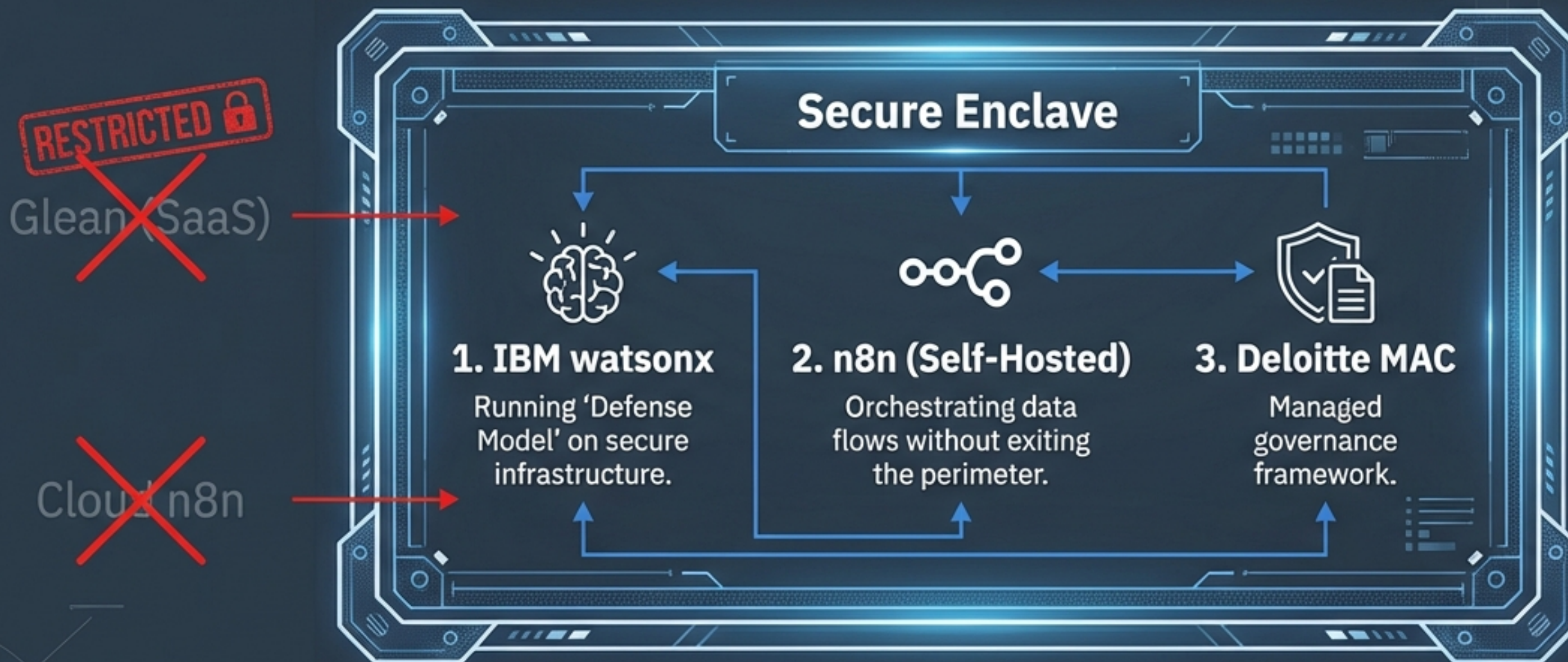
Model suggests design optimizations based on historical failure modes.

Result: Faster design iterations and reduced 'reinventing the wheel'.

Use Case: Resilient Supply Chain & Manufacturing Operations



Use Case: Defense & Mission Systems (Classified Environments)

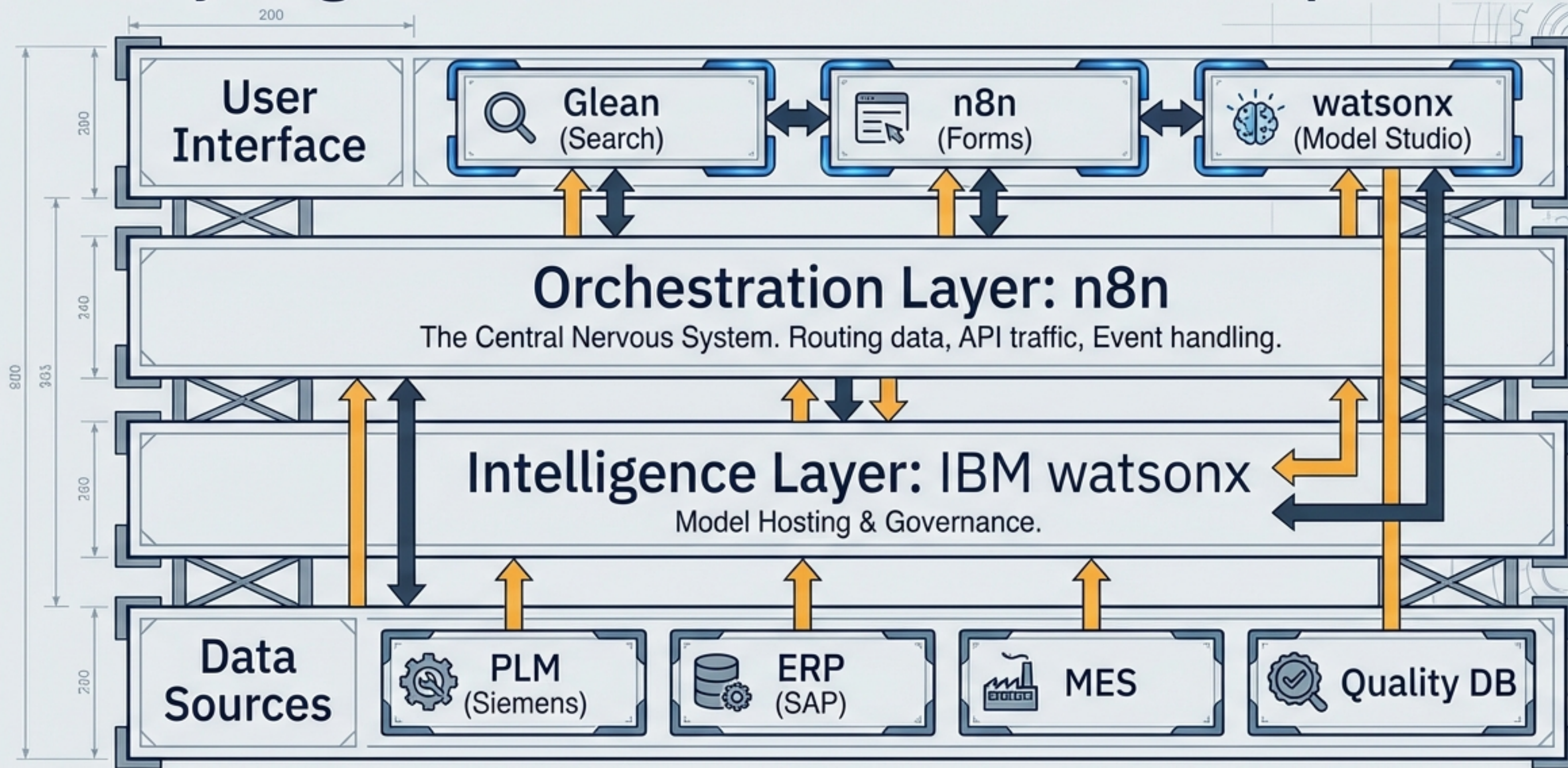


For classified intel and mission planning, SaaS solutions are excluded.
On-premise, air-gapped architecture is mandatory.

Decision Matrix: Selecting the Right Tool for the Objective

Organizational Priority		Best Fit Platform
Cost Minimization	➡	 n8n Free self-hosted option, low infrastructure cost.
Security / Classified	➡	 IBM watsonx Only platform with explicit air-gapped/defense capability.
Speed to Productivity	➡	 Glean Instant indexing, intuitive UI, high user adoption.
Strategic Transformation	➡	 Deloitte . MAC Deep industry expertise, change management.
No Vendor Lock-in	➡	 n8n Open-source core, portable workflows.

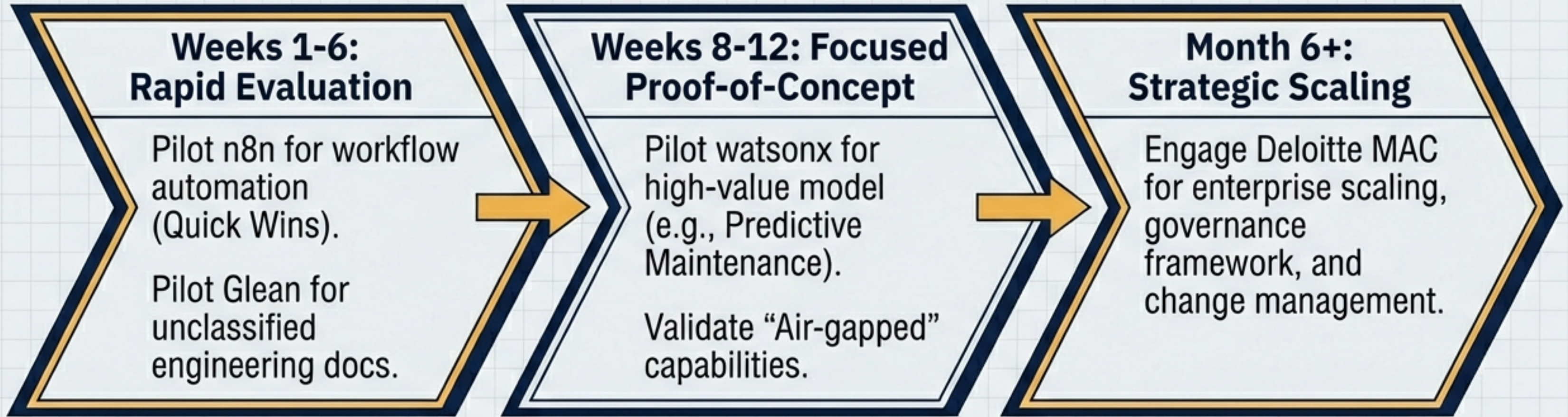
The Synergistic Architecture: A Unified Aerospace Stack



Glean finds the data, n8n moves the data, watsonx thinks about the data.



Implementation Roadmap: From Pilot to Scale



RFP Guidance:

Ask vendors specifically about ITAR support and Air-gapped options—these are the key differentiators.



Strategic Recommendation: Build a 'Silver Shield,' Not a Silver Bullet

Small/Mid-Size Strategy

Center on n8n + Glean.

⚙️ Focus: High productivity, manageable cost, speed to value.

Large Defense Strategy

Center on watsonx + n8n (Self-Hosted) + Deloitte.

🛡️ Focus: Maximum security, compliance, governance, air-gapped operations.

The competitive advantage in 2026 comes from **CONNECTING** these capabilities. **Agentic AI** and **edge inference** will define the next decade of aerospace efficiency.